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Ricardo Gonzalez & Carmen Le Foulon Morán

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BRIEF REPORT



The 2019–2020 Chilean protests: A first look at their causes and participants

Ricardo Gonzalez^a and Carmen Le Foulon Morán^b

^aEscuela de Comunicaciones y Periodismo, Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez, Santiago de Chile, Chile; ^bCentro de Estudios Públicos, Santiago de Chile, Chile

ABSTRACT

On 18 October 2019, after weeks of subway fare evasions in a protest for a fare increase, protesters occupied some stations of the Metropolitan Public Transport Network in Santiago, Chile's capital city. An explosive and surprising escalation of violence ensued later that night marking the beginning of an ongoing social crisis that extended to other regions of the country, and reshaped, probably permanently, the political landscape.

It is not yet possible to provide a definitive account of events that are still unfolding. We do not aim (nor can) settle the debate, nor give an exhaustive account of all arguments in such a short text. Instead, we describe the main facts of the still ongoing social crisis and the context leading to this crisis, and suggest some explanations based on current body of research and on survey data fielded during the crisis.

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On 18 October 2019, protesters occupied some stations of the Metropolitan Public Transport Network in Santiago, Chile's capital city, as a reaction to the increase in the subway fare, leading to the early close of the subway system. An explosive escalation of violence ensued later that night, leading to chaos first on the streets of Santiago and then in major cities across the country. The protests' support and quick expansion, and especially the surge and spread of the violence, took everyone by surprise.

The objective of this short article is to describe the context and main facts of the still ongoing social crisis in Chile, and suggest some explanations based on the current body of research and on survey data fielded during the crisis. There is still debate among academics and political actors about causes, main actors and motivations as well as their level of organization. We do not aim (nor can) settle the debate, nor give an exhaustive account of all arguments here. For that reason, issues such as social mobility, deceleration of economic progress, high expectations, and anomie, to name a few, will not be specifically analyzed in this text. Instead, we provide some context and data, as well as address the main demands.

The first section describes the progress and the challenges of the Chilean society over the last three decades. The second section presents a brief overview of the recent

evolution of protests and mobilizations in Chile. The third section describes protesters and supporters analytically, using a survey fielded during the crisis, and findings from previous research. The fourth section concludes and discusses some key scheduled events.

Context

In terms of GDP per capita, Chile had a very successful performance over the last thirty years. In contrast to other countries from the region, the economic progress in Chile did not experience major setbacks over the last three decades, turning it into the medium-size country that has shortened the most its distance to the average OECD country in terms of GDP per capita. There has been progress in the social front as well. Life expectancy at birth increased, child mortality decreased, and poverty levels dropped sharply, placing Chile in the highest position within Latin America. Life satisfaction and happiness levels have increased over time. In fact, year after year, Chile has been the happiest country in South America, according to the World Happiness Report, although it lost this position in 2019.

Amidst the economic and social progress, the state of political representation began raising concerns. The electoral stability of the party system co-exists with socially uprooted parties that are no longer perceived as vehicles of social demands (Valenzuela and Dammert 2006; Altman and Luna 2011; Siavelis 2016). Electoral participation has decreased steadily since the 1989 election, from over 90% to just 49% in the second round of the 2017 presidential election. Political identification has fallen dramatically, from about 80% of the urban population in 1990 to 19% in May 2019 (CEP surveys¹), a faster dealignment process than the one observed in other countries across the region (Bargsted and Maldonado 2018). Trust in parties as well as in Congress have also declined over the last decade; although distrust extends beyond political institutions, reaching mass media, the Catholic church, the army and police forces.

Even though income inequality slightly decreased in Chile between 1990 and 2017, along with its perception (see section “Who protests and why”), income inequality after taxes and transfers remains high. Furthermore, economic progress and upward mobility contributed to enlarge the size of the middle class, increasing short- and long-term expectations about the satisfaction of social needs. These have been difficult to meet by the current institutional framework, especially when it comes to the problems associated with the access to higher pensions and high-quality health and education services.

In parallel, as parties were increasingly perceived as elite-driven and out of touch of citizens concerns, contentious forms of collective action rose, as Tarrow (2011) has argued. Social protests steadily increased during the 2000s, and events more than doubled during that decade according to some studies (PNUD 2015; Donoso and von Bülow 2017). As Roberts (2016, 128) argues, the politization of social needs and inequality lies at the heart of this cycle. The main participants on this cycle were student movements. Starting with high school students’ protests in 2006, which continued cyclically over the years, the 2011 student protest consolidated its predominance shaping the political agenda. Contentious actions remained stable in the following years (2012–2017), except for political and labor movements (Garretón et al. 2018). Indeed, a

relevant actor emerged in 2016 among labor protesters: No + AFP – which means no more privately administered pension funds. This movement has gained momentum in the current events and anticipated the politicization of a new dimension of inequality: pensions, which became a focal point in the current protests.

The origins and escalation of the social crisis

On 4 October 2019, the expert panel in charge of setting the fare of the Metropolitan Public Transport Network in Santiago decided to increase the subway fare from about USD 1.12 to USD 1.16, or 0.276% of the minimum wage.² Two days later, the increase was implemented. In protest, high school students from Instituto Nacional, the most renowned public school in the country, started to avoid payment by hopping turnstiles every day starting on 7 October 2019. Evasions intensified the following week as students from other schools joined them by targeting several Metro stations across Santiago. As a reaction against these events, the subway authority closed some of those stations. Others kept functioning under heavy police surveillance, eventually leading to violent clashes between students and Carabineros on 17 October 2019. The next day, protesters occupied some of the subway stations and vandalized others, leading to the early closing of the subway system. About 2.5 million users clogged the streets of Santiago trying to get back home.

An explosive escalation of violence ensued later that night. Seven subway stations were burned within an hour that day. On that weekend, 77 subway stations were completely damaged, and about 450 supermarkets were looted and set on fire. Citizens at their homes and on the streets were bashing saucepans as a sign of protest against the government. The violence continued and extended beyond the capital city. On 20 October 2019, President Piñera declared State of Emergency in the capital city for the first time since Pinochet's military dictatorship, which was extended to other regions of the country. But the violence did not abate.

At the same time, citizens gathered in public spaces to demonstrate against the government, demanding fairness, higher pensions, better public services and a new Constitution (see next section). These massive demonstrations across the country also led to the organization of self-arranged meetings in public spaces with the aim of analyzing the social crisis and creating proposals for change.

On 21 October 2019, the Congress passed a new law, eliminating the increase of the public transport fare and the day after, President Piñera announced a new social agenda, including a 20% increase in pensions for low-income households, an increase in the minimum income, higher taxes for the “super rich,” suspension of electricity rate hikes, among other policies. The announcements did not stop the protesters as several violent clashes between civilians and the military spread across the country over that week. On 25 October 2019, nearly 1.2 million people demonstrated in Santiago, the highest concentration over the last 30 years. Next day, President Piñera declared the end of the State of Emergency. He also asked the resignation of all his cabinet members, although not all of them were replaced two days later.

Once the army was off the streets, peaceful demonstrations and violent clashes between some protesters and Carabineros continued. On 15 November 2019, after a

week of renewed violence, an agreement backed by almost all political parties was signed. The most notable absences were the Communist Party, which was vocal against such agreement, and some political parties belonging to Frente Amplio, a left-wing coalition. The so-called “Agreement for Peace” (*Acuerdo por la Paz*) included a call to a referendum scheduled on 26 April 2020 on the question of a new Constitution and the drafting mechanism: a mixed convention (integrated by citizens and members of Congress) or a constituent convention (integrated by citizens only).

Since the start of the social crisis, there have been reports of human rights violations. The National Institute of Human Rights began its work by reporting the number of detentions and human rights violations, including the injured by rubber-bullets daily, especially those with ocular trauma, and by investigating those reports. Several international missions arrived to the country, including a UN mission, all with the aim of investigating human rights violations. These developments seem to echo those occurred in France since the start of the so-called yellow vest movement (*gilet jaune*),³ although numbers in Chile are much higher.

The Chilean Association of Municipalities decided to organize a referendum to consult citizens on a new Constitution on 15 December 2019. Turnout was about 2.5 million citizens⁴ and nine out of ten voters supported the option of drafting a new Constitution. This referendum and its results were not organized nor supervised by the electoral authority.

At the time of writing, it has been five months since the start of the crisis. During January and especially February 2020, the traditional summer holiday months in Chile, the social movement lost some strength, but peaceful demonstrations and violent clashes between protesters and Carabineros kept going, especially in Plaza Baquedano, the most important square of Santiago, as well as attacks to some police stations. Protests and riots resumed in the first half of March 2020, but they came to a halt after the Government decreed the closure of non-essential shops, schools and universities on 15 March 2020, to curb the spread of the COVID-19. Amid a growing concern over the disease expansion, parties from all the political spectrum agreed to reschedule the referendum to 25 October 2020.

Who protests and why

One of the most striking, and more challenging aspects of the protests is the diversity of actors and lack of a valid interlocutor. Contrary to previous protests, we do not observe the emergence of new leaders (or the validation of old ones). Some protests were spontaneous, and others were organized by unions and social movements such as No + AFP, workers of the public health care system, feminist groups, and No + Tag, an organization against the payment of tolls for using the highways, to name a few. In this case, diversity of participants implied a huge heterogeneity of demands. However, according to those surveyed by CEP in December 2019, the main grievances underlying the peaceful protests are income inequality, low income after retirement, the rising cost of living, and the low quality of publicly funded healthcare and education services.

Perceptions of inequality sharply increased between May and December 2019: the ratio of perceived income earned by a president of a major company over a blue-collar

worker jumped from 21 in May to 30 in December (it was 32 in 2009).⁵ This change is driven by the increase in the perception of the income earned by the president of a major company. At the same time, ratio of justified inequality decreased from 8 in May to 6 in December 2019 (it was 11 in 2009), driven by an increase in the desired income for a blue-collar worker.

Income inequality is also associated to the access to high-quality healthcare and education services. Higher income facilitates the access to privately funded healthcare and education services, whose quality tends to be higher than their publicly funded counterparts. This means that when a sudden disease affects a household member or kids need to go to a good school, the family may not be able to afford it or if they do, the family budget can suffer, threatening family's progress. Thus, the insecurity associated to these events is widespread, even among high and middle classes (Gonzalez 2018).

In the first days of the crisis, many accounts related the protests to abuses from both the public and private sectors, discriminatory behavior and an overall sense of unfair advantages that benefited the few against the many: a dimension of inequality associated to social inequalities and power disparities (Somma 2017; Palet et al. 2017). According to PNUD-DES-2016 survey, 41% of respondents experienced discrimination, mistreatments or being looked down. Similarly, 46% of CEP respondents in December 2019 reported experiencing mistreatment in at least one of the six situations presented in the survey.⁶

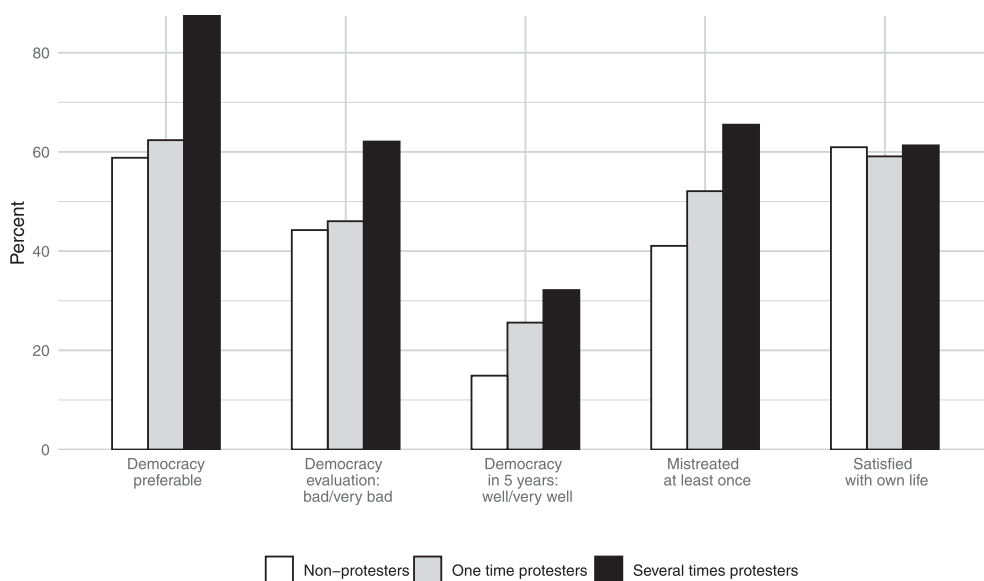
These perceptions contrast with the widespread life satisfaction and happiness among Chileans. Several factors may account for this gap. First, the difference between perception of own life versus the rest: respondents declared themselves very satisfied with their lives but believed there was high dissatisfaction among the rest of the population. Gonzalez and Mackenna (2017) show that this gap was greater in respondents with higher socioeconomic status, highly educated and with high media consumption. The gap is also higher among young people (between 18 and 34 years old) who are more likely to protest. This group also tends to have a different value system than older groups, as Inglehart and Welzel (2005) suggest, as they were socialized in the period of the highest economic growth of the Chilean history, also enjoying of civil liberties after the dictatorship, and therefore, they internalized different value patterns to those of previous generations (Gonzalez 2018).

Analyzing the data of the December CEP survey, 17% of respondents declared to have participated several times in a protest since 18 October 2019, whereas 10% stated that they have participated once. Protesters do not identify different grievances justifying protests than those who did not participate, except for the low quality of public health and education which is more frequently reported by protesters ($F(1.93, 465.4) = 5.58$).⁷ We do not observe different rates of participation by gender ($F(1.91, 459.6) = 0.46$), but we see strong age and education effects, consistent with the notion of critical citizens (Norris 1999). Whereas 55% of 18–24 years old participated at least once in the protests, 37% of those between 25 and 34 did, and the percentage decreases further with age, so that those 55 or older, only 12% participated at least once ($F(7.34, 1769.7) = 15.0$). As expected, participation in protest is also strongly associated with education levels ($F(5.45, 1313.2) = 19.30$): whereas only 8% of those with 8 years of education or less

protested at least once compared to the 30% of those with high school education – including at least one year of high school and those with completed high school. Among those with at least one year of tertiary education 41% participated at least once.

There is evidence of a democratic deficit among Chilean citizens which is particularly strong among protesters, as the theory would predict since it affects contentious politics (Norris 2011). CEP survey permits to evaluate four of its five components: there is evidence of low support for all, except for regime.⁸ As shown in Figure 1, protesters, in particular, those who protested several times, are more likely to prefer democracy as institution, but are more critical of its functioning. Among those who protested several times, 87% prefers democracy compared with 63% and 59% of those who protested once and never ($F(5.48, 1321.7) = 8.28$), respectively. When asked about how well democracy works in Chile, 62% of protesters says that bad or very badly versus 46% of one-time protesters and 44% of non-protesters ($F(5.39, 1299.4) = 3.29$). Confidence is low for all citizens as well as government approval – which achieved a historical low in 6%. Notably, several time protesters are more optimistic as 31% of them think that in 5 years democracy will work well or very well, versus 26% of one-time protesters and 15% of non-protesters ($F(7.32, 1764.80) = 3.94$).

Perception of mistreatment is associated to protest, supporting those accounts relating the protests to a widespread feeling of unfair advantages that benefited the few against the many. Indeed, as Figure 1 shows, several time protesters are more likely to report having experienced mistreatment than one-time protesters and non-protesters. Nevertheless, these differences are not reflected in differences in life satisfaction: regardless of participation levels, protesters and non-protesters alike are highly satisfied with their lives ($F(3.80, 914.76) = 0.18$). This suggests that the rise of protests in Chile cannot be explained by personal dissatisfaction (Gonzalez 2017; Somma 2017).



Source: CEP December 2019

Figure 1. Attitudes and perceptions by protest intensity.

A note on violence

Perhaps the most striking and puzzling feature was the rapid spread and unusual intensity of violence. Indeed, justification of violence is also associated with contentious activities, as 51% of protesters justify at least sometimes to participate in barricades compared with 31% of those that only protested once and 11% among those who did not protest. The differences persist when comparing within age groups. When asked about justification for setting buildings and shops on fire as form of protest, 15% of those who participated several times justify it at least sometimes, versus 6% of those who did not participate.

It is possible to interpret the violence by protesters and the police as part of a vicious cycle where the legitimacy of Carabineros is at the center (Alenda 2020; Tyler 2006). Carabineros have been increasingly perceived as illegitimate which may reduce citizen's cooperation and law obedience (Tyler and Huo 2002). First, since 2017, high-ranking police officers have been investigated for malfeasance, reducing the trust in Carabineros, which was 65% in 2009 and has plummeted to 17% at the end of 2019 (CEP surveys). Second, several Carabineros are currently under investigation for violating human rights at several points during the social crisis. Indeed, protesters are less likely to justify the use of force by Carabineros against a violent demonstrator than non-protesters; and are much more likely to consider that Carabineros violated human rights always or almost always during the crisis. The violence by protesters has led the authorities to take more aggressive policies, e.g. by sending the army onto the streets during the State of Emergency. As the survey data show, most of the public perceived these measures as unfair, more so if human right violations are added to the mix, reducing Carabineros' legitimacy further. Indeed, a survey of protesters in Plaza Baquedano shows that 49% of them were there in response to the declaration of the State of Emergency and curfew.⁹ This may further justify the violence by the citizens against Carabineros, leading to a violence spiral between both groups (Maguire et al, 2018). In this sense, what we have witnessed since 18 October 2019 is similar to what happened to the Mapuche people -the main indigenous group in Chile, which has been in conflict with the State for about two centuries-, but now at a national level (CEP Mapuche survey 2016; Gerber et al. 2018).

Final remarks

Undoubtedly, the political landscape was reshaped by the protests, and reforms that were unthinkable a few months ago, are being discussed in Congress. A case in point is the writing of a new Constitution. Sebastián Piñera was the only candidate that did not explicitly advocate for a new Constitution and yet was elected (Sierra 2020). Now his administration has to manage the referendum on October 2020 and the eventual voting of the assembly members in charge of writing the new Constitution on April 2021. The referendum approving or rejecting the resulting Constitution will be managed by a new administration in 2022. Campaigns in favor or against the new Constitution, which will resume once the urgency of the health crisis due to COVID-19 has decreased, will probably contribute to further changes in the political landscape.

The crisis was still unfolding when the COVID-19 started to spread across the country. It will probably resume after it is under control, but the circumstances will be dramatically different. The social and economic impacts of the pandemic will likely affect the priorities and incentives of all actors, in ways that are difficult to predict. Therefore, it is not possible to provide a definitive account of these events. The crisis initiated on 18 October 2019 will surely inspire new research. This article is our first attempt in understanding the events that changed the lives of a whole nation.

Notes

1. CEP survey is multi-stage, probabilistic face-to-face survey. The design involves three stages: first, PSUs are randomly selected within strata defined over regional and urban/rural divide based on the relevant Census. PSU consists of block in urban areas and entities in rural zones. Within PSU, households are randomly selected, and finally, individuals 18 year or older are randomly selected within each household. Hence, there is a known probability of selection for each individual used to construct weights which also incorporates adjustments due to non-response based on region, urban/rural divide, gender and age. There is no substitution, and hence, an over-sample is calculated in order to achieve about 1,500 interviews since 2010. CEP is member of ISSP since 1998.
2. We thank Alvaro Cordero and Adolfo Fuentes for their calculations.
3. "France admits its police are too violent", *The Economist*, 23 January 2020.
4. Of those, online voting accounted for 43% of the vote, which is important to note is not allowed for other elections. Data accessed on 3 February 2020 from <https://bulletin.consultamunicipal.cl/> and <https://www.consultaciudadana2019.cl/II>.
5. We thank Andrea Escobar for her research assistance on inequality trends from CEP surveys.
6. Those situations are: their working place, the street, health services, government services, municipal offices, and banks or other commercial offices.
7. Estimated with STATA 13, reporting design-based F values.
8. Norris identifies five components: belonging to the national community, support for general regime principles, evaluations of the overall performance of the regime, confidence in state institutions and trust in elected and appointed officeholders. Only the first component is not evaluated in CEP survey.
9. Nucleo de Sociología Contigente (NUDESOC) University of Chile students <http://www.nudesoc.cl/>

Notes on contributors

Ricardo Gonzalez is the director of a survey research center at the Escuela de Comunicaciones y Periodismo, Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez. Previously, he was the coordinator of the Public Opinion Program at Centro de Estudios Públicos as well as of the International Social Survey Program (ISSP) in Chile, both from September 2013 to January 2020.

Carmen Le Foulon Morán is the coordinator of the Public Opinion Program at Centro de Estudios Públicos, and of the International Social Survey Program (ISSP) in Chile. Member of Red de Politólogos.

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